

ECOMMERCE PLATFORM RESEARCH

Salesforce Commerce Cloud, Shopify Apps, and Hydrogen

A practical comparison of platforms, missing capabilities, and headless storefront development

Prepared as a focused research report

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REPORT MAP

01**SFCC vs. Shopify**

A short enterprise-level comparison

02**Shopify Apps**

Popular apps and the gaps they fill

03**Shopify Hydrogen**

How headless storefronts work and when they make sense

Shopify can work as a ready-to-run ecommerce platform, but it can also be extended through apps or rebuilt as a headless storefront. This report looks at where Salesforce Commerce Cloud fits beside Shopify, which common Shopify gaps are usually covered by apps, and what Hydrogen changes when a brand wants more control over the storefront.

Quick view

Salesforce Commerce Cloud is usually the heavier enterprise choice. Standard Shopify is easier to launch and operate. Apps add specialist features, while Hydrogen is for brands that need a custom React storefront rather than a standard theme.

01 Salesforce Commerce Cloud vs. Shopify

What each platform is

Salesforce Commerce Cloud (SFCC) is an enterprise commerce platform for B2C and B2B businesses. It is a natural fit for companies already using Salesforce CRM, Data Cloud, Service Cloud, or Marketing Cloud because commerce can sit inside the same broader ecosystem. Salesforce also supports composable storefronts through PWA Kit and Managed Runtime. [1][2]

Shopify is a hosted commerce platform that covers the storefront, product catalog, checkout, orders, inventory, payments, and sales channels. Shopify Plus extends the same platform for larger and higher-volume businesses without changing the basic operating model. [3]

Main comparison

Area	Shopify	Salesforce Commerce Cloud
Best fit	Growing brands and enterprises that want simpler operations	Large enterprises with complex Salesforce-centered operations
Implementation	Usually faster, with a lower technical barrier	Usually a larger implementation involving partners and specialist teams
Daily management	Friendly for ecommerce, marketing, and operations teams	More enterprise-focused and often more technical
Customization	Themes, apps, APIs, Functions, and Hydrogen	Deep enterprise configuration plus composable storefront tools
CRM and customer data	Integrates with CRM and data platforms	Strong native connection to the Salesforce ecosystem
Pricing approach	Published standard plans; Shopify Plus uses enterprise pricing	Many Commerce Cloud editions are contract-based and some use GMV-based pricing
Headless option	Hydrogen, Oxygen, and Storefront API	Composable Storefront with PWA Kit and Managed Runtime

When SFCC makes more sense

- The company already runs a large part of its customer, service, and marketing work inside Salesforce.
- Commerce rules, customer segments, markets, and workflows are highly complex.
- The project has an enterprise budget, a specialist implementation team, and a longer rollout timeline.

- Deep coordination between commerce, CRM, service, and customer data is more important than simplicity.

When Shopify makes more sense

- The business wants to launch or migrate faster.
- Non-technical teams need to manage products, promotions, and orders without depending on developers for every change.
- The company prefers a large app ecosystem and a platform that can grow without rebuilding the core infrastructure.
- A simpler operating model is more valuable than deep Salesforce-native integration.

Bottom line

SFCC is stronger when enterprise complexity and Salesforce integration lead the decision. Shopify is usually the more practical choice when speed, usability, and lower operational overhead matter more.

02 Popular Shopify Apps and the Gaps They Cover

Shopify covers the core work of running a store, but most mature brands still add specialist tools. The apps below were selected because they are prominent in their categories and have strong merchant adoption and review activity in the Shopify App Store. This is not an official ranking, since Shopify does not publish complete installation numbers for every app. [4]

App review counts change frequently. The report focuses on what the apps do rather than treating review numbers as a permanent ranking.

At a glance

App	Main use	What Shopify already has	What the app adds
Klaviyo	Email, SMS, and lifecycle marketing	Shopify Email, customer data, basic automation	Deeper segmentation, multi-step flows, testing, predictive and lifecycle marketing
Judge.me	Product reviews and user-generated content	Product pages and customer records	Automated review requests, photo/video reviews, widgets, ratings, and syndication
Recharge	Subscriptions and recurring revenue	Native subscription support and selling plans	Advanced subscriber retention, failed-payment recovery, portals, bundles, and analytics
PageFly	Landing pages and page design	Theme editor and sections	More drag-and-drop layout control without custom Liquid or CSS
Smile.io	Loyalty and referrals	Discounts, customers, and store credit features	Points, VIP tiers, referral programs, branded rewards, and loyalty analytics

Klaviyo - Advanced email, SMS, and customer journeys

Klaviyo connects Shopify order, customer, product, and browsing data to marketing campaigns and automated flows. Typical uses include welcome series, abandoned-cart messages, post-purchase follow-ups, win-back campaigns, and detailed audience segments.

What it fills: The gap it covers is not simply sending email. It adds a deeper marketing engine for brands that want to react to customer behavior and measure each stage of the customer lifecycle.

Judge.me - Reviews, ratings, photos, and videos

Judge.me collects reviews through email, SMS, or QR codes and displays ratings, review widgets, photos, videos, and testimonials on the storefront. It can also reward reviewers and share review content to other channels.

What it fills: Shopify provides the product page, but a full review workflow is not part of the basic store experience. Judge.me adds collection, moderation, display, and social-proof tools.

Recharge - Subscriptions and subscriber retention

Recharge is aimed at stores where recurring revenue is a major part of the business. It manages subscription plans, recurring billing, self-service customer portals, failed-payment recovery, bundles, cancellation flows, and retention reporting.

What it fills: Shopify can support subscriptions, but Recharge becomes useful when the subscription model needs more control over churn, subscriber behavior, bundles, and long-term value.

PageFly - Flexible landing pages without a full custom build

PageFly gives merchants a drag-and-drop page builder for landing pages, product pages, campaign pages, homepages, and custom sections. It sits between the standard theme editor and a fully custom frontend.

What it fills: The main gap is layout freedom. Shopify themes are flexible, but their editor is still limited by the structure of the theme. PageFly gives non-developers more room to create campaign-specific pages.

Smile.io - Loyalty points, VIP levels, and referrals

Smile.io adds a structured loyalty program where customers can earn points, move through VIP tiers, receive rewards, and invite friends through referrals.

What it fills: Shopify manages customers, orders, discounts, and store credit, but it does not provide a complete loyalty framework by default. Smile.io adds the rules and customer experience around repeat purchasing.

What these apps show about Shopify

- Shopify is designed as a strong core platform rather than a system that tries to build every specialist tool itself.
- The biggest app-driven gaps are usually retention, reviews, subscriptions, advanced marketing, and design flexibility.
- Apps let a store add features quickly, but several paid apps can raise monthly costs and create more vendors to manage.
- A business should check whether an app works through theme blocks, APIs, checkout extensions, or headless integrations before choosing it.

Practical trade-off

Apps are one of Shopify's strengths because they make the platform flexible. The trade-off is that a store can become dependent on several subscriptions and integrations if it keeps solving every requirement with another app.

03 Shopify Hydrogen

Hydrogen in plain language

Hydrogen is Shopify's React-based framework for building custom headless storefronts. Instead of using a normal Shopify theme, developers build the customer-facing website as a separate application. Shopify still manages the catalog, inventory, customers, cart, checkout, orders, and payments behind the scenes. [5]

How the setup works



The storefront is custom-built, while Shopify remains the commerce engine.

The main parts of the Hydrogen stack

Part	Role	What it means in practice
Hydrogen	Frontend framework	React Router-based tools, components, utilities, and patterns made for Shopify storefronts.
Storefront API	Commerce data layer	The storefront reads products, collections, prices, carts, customer data, and other Shopify information through APIs.
Oxygen	Hosting and deployment	Shopify's edge hosting environment for Hydrogen, with deployments, previews, caching, and platform integration.
Shopify Admin	Commerce operations	Merchants keep managing products, orders, inventory, discounts, customers, and markets in Shopify.

Why a business would use Hydrogen

- The brand needs a storefront experience that a standard theme cannot deliver cleanly.
- The website must combine Shopify commerce with an external CMS, product-information system, personalization service, or other data source.
- Developers need full control over navigation, product discovery, content, interactions, and frontend architecture.
- The same commerce data needs to support more than one experience, such as a website, app, kiosk, or regional storefront.
- Performance, frontend experimentation, and custom UX are strategic requirements rather than small design preferences.

Main benefits

More design freedom: The team is not limited by Liquid templates or the structure of a purchased theme.

Shopify-focused developer tools: Hydrogen includes clients, components, and patterns already designed around Shopify APIs and commerce flows.

Flexible data sources: The storefront can combine Shopify data with a CMS, search platform, reviews service, or other APIs.

Modern rendering and caching: Hydrogen supports server rendering, streaming, route-based data loading, and caching patterns for storefront performance.

Integrated deployment with Oxygen: Teams can connect development and deployment workflows without choosing a separate hosting stack.

Limitations and extra responsibility

It needs developers: Hydrogen is not a drag-and-drop builder. The team needs React and modern web-development skills.

The launch is usually slower: A theme can be configured quickly; a custom storefront needs design, development, testing, analytics setup, and quality assurance.

App compatibility changes: Apps that insert blocks or Liquid code into a theme will not automatically appear in a headless storefront. The app needs an API, SDK, or headless integration.

The frontend becomes your responsibility: Shopify still manages the commerce backend, but the business owns more of the storefront code, monitoring, testing, and maintenance.

Custom does not always mean better: A headless build adds value only when the business has a real requirement that the normal theme approach cannot handle well.

Hydrogen vs. a standard Shopify theme

Area	Standard Shopify theme	Hydrogen storefront
Frontend technology	Liquid, theme editor, sections, and app blocks	React Router application built with Hydrogen
Launch speed	Usually faster	Usually slower because it is a custom build
Design freedom	Good, but shaped by the theme	Very high
Developer need	Low to medium	High
App compatibility	Most theme apps integrate more easily	Apps may need APIs or custom integration
Maintenance	Lower frontend ownership	Ongoing code, testing, and deployment responsibility
Best fit	Most standard and moderately customized stores	Brands with a clear headless or highly custom requirement

When Hydrogen is probably unnecessary

- The desired design can already be achieved with a modern Shopify theme and a few well-chosen apps.
- The business does not have a development team for ongoing maintenance.
- Marketing staff need to control most page changes without developer support.
- Fast launch and lower cost are more important than a fully custom frontend.
- Most required apps depend heavily on theme blocks or theme code.

A simple decision rule

Use Hydrogen because the business needs a custom storefront, not because headless commerce sounds more advanced. For many stores, a well-built Shopify theme is still the faster and more cost-effective solution.

04 Conclusion

Salesforce Commerce Cloud and Shopify can both support large ecommerce operations, but they solve the problem differently. SFCC is a stronger fit for highly complex, Salesforce-centered enterprises. Shopify is generally easier to launch, manage, and extend.

Shopify apps cover specialist needs such as advanced marketing, reviews, subscriptions, flexible page building, and loyalty. This gives merchants choice, although it can also add cost and integration work.

Hydrogen goes further by replacing the theme-based storefront with a custom React application while keeping Shopify as the commerce backend. It is most useful when a brand has a real UX, integration, or architecture requirement that a normal theme cannot meet.

Recommended choice by situation

Situation	Most suitable direction
Complex enterprise already centered on Salesforce	Salesforce Commerce Cloud
Need faster implementation and easier operations	Standard Shopify or Shopify Plus
Need one specialist feature	Add a carefully selected Shopify app
Need a truly custom headless storefront	Shopify Hydrogen
Need only a more flexible campaign page	Use a page-builder app before considering a full headless build

05 References - Five Primary Websites

The report uses official platform and developer sources. The five websites below were used for platform features, pricing models, app capabilities, and Hydrogen architecture.

- [1] **Salesforce Commerce Cloud** - Commerce products, editions, enterprise capabilities, and pricing information.
<https://www.salesforce.com/commerce/>
- [2] **Salesforce Developers - Composable Storefront** - PWA Kit, Managed Runtime, and Salesforce headless storefront documentation. <https://developer.salesforce.com/docs/commerce/pwa-kit-managed-runtime/>
- [3] **Shopify and Shopify Plus** - Core Shopify platform and enterprise commerce information.
<https://www.shopify.com/plus>
- [4] **Shopify App Store** - Official app listings for Klaviyo, Judge.me, Recharge, PageFly, and Smile.io.
<https://apps.shopify.com/>
- [5] **Shopify Developer Documentation** - Hydrogen, Oxygen, Storefront API, Customer Account API, and headless storefront guidance. <https://shopify.dev/docs/storefronts/headless/hydrogen/>

Source pages consulted

- Salesforce Commerce pricing and B2C Commerce product pages.
- Salesforce Composable Storefront and PWA Kit documentation.
- Shopify Plus platform and enterprise pages.
- Official Shopify App Store listings and category pages.
- Shopify Hydrogen and Oxygen fundamentals, API, and deployment documentation.

Accessed and reviewed in June 2026. App ratings, review counts, pricing, and product details may change over time.